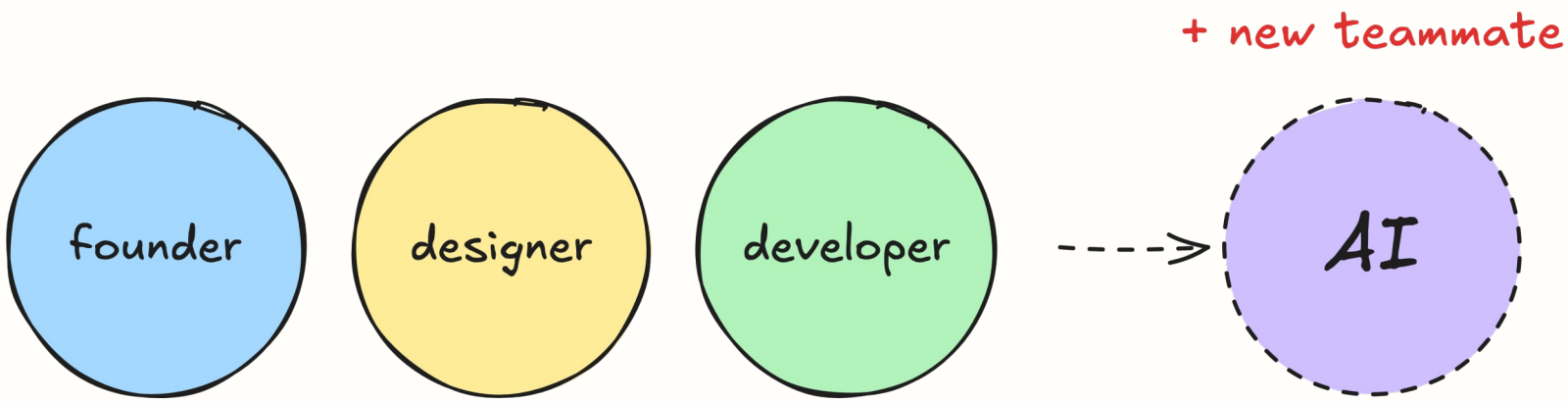
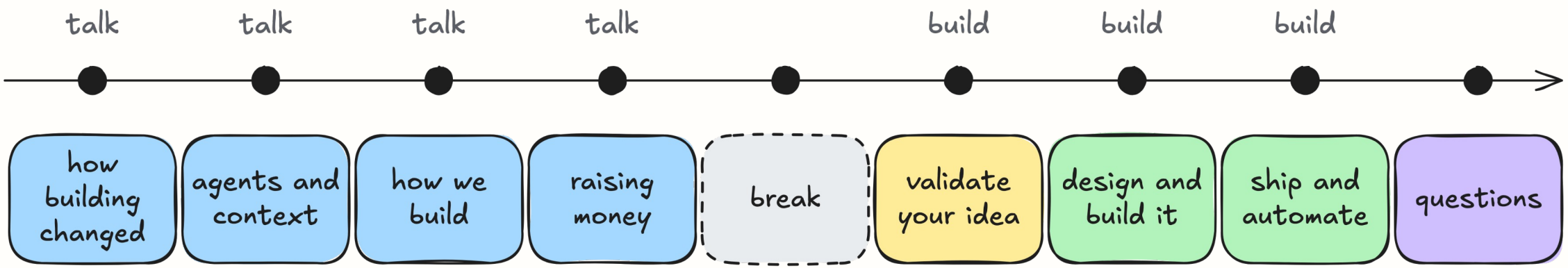
Building
in the Age of AI

First the talk, then we build your idea together.



Today

Talk first, then we build your idea together. Laptop open? Follow along.



Follow along on your laptop:
github.com/ritmillio/building-in-the-age-of-ai

What are we building today?

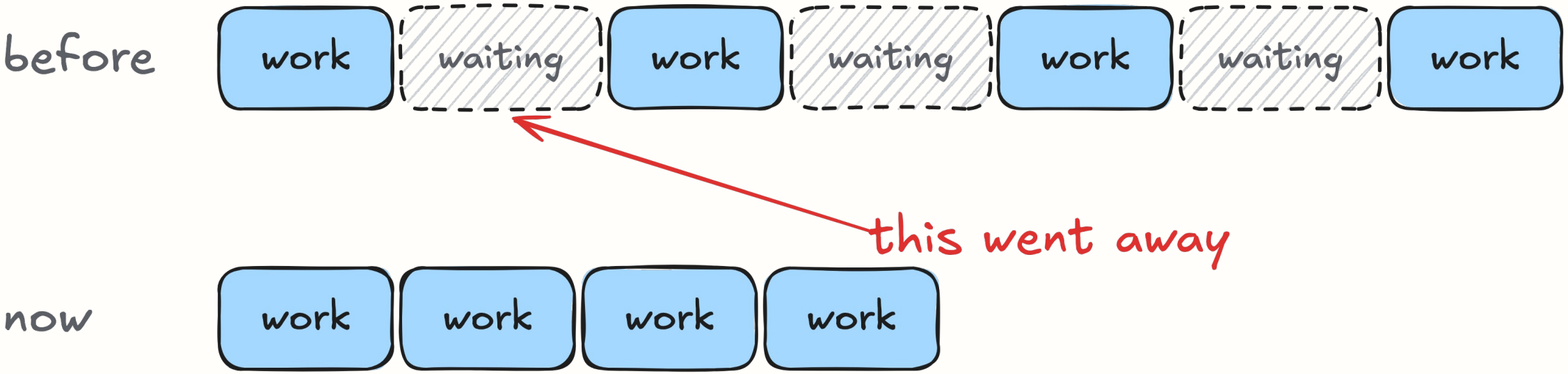
Shout out a problem you would pay to get solved. Hands up for the best one.



a good pick

- ✓ a real problem you have seen
- ✓ someone would pay to fix it
- ✓ small enough for one afternoon

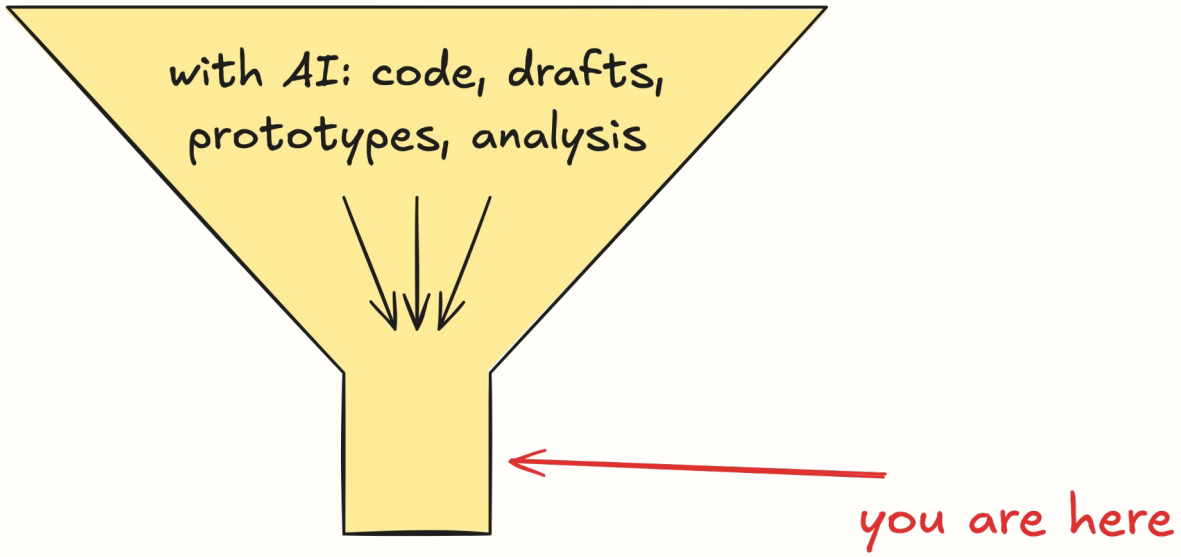
AI didn't take the work,
it took the waiting.



No more waiting for the plan, the review, the missing information or the code.

If building is no longer the slow part,
who is the bottleneck?

You.



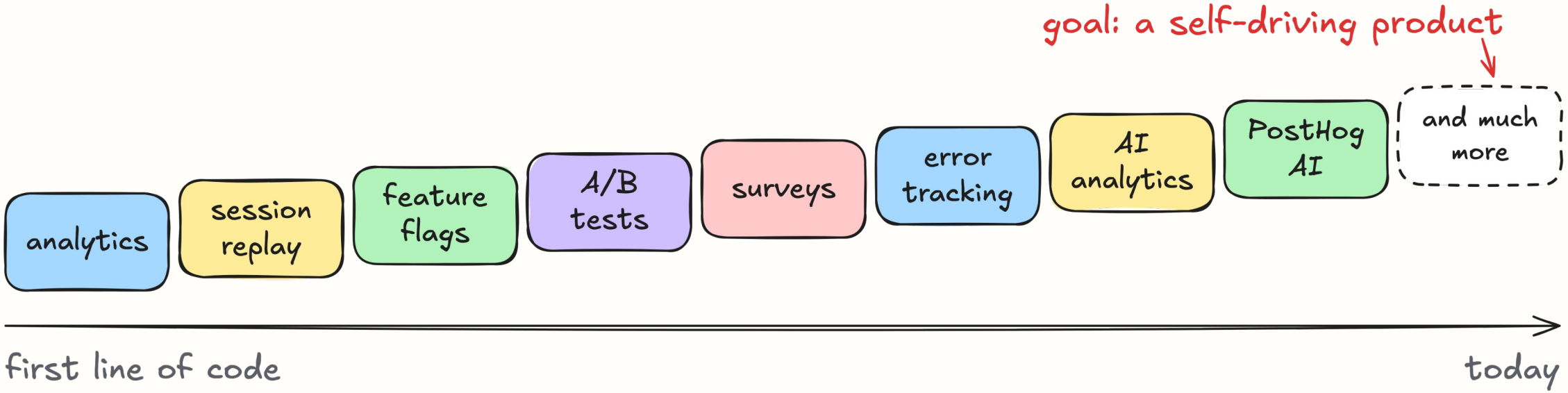
Taste. Customer knowledge. Judgment.

None of these got faster.

PostHog

They built the company to be fast, on purpose.

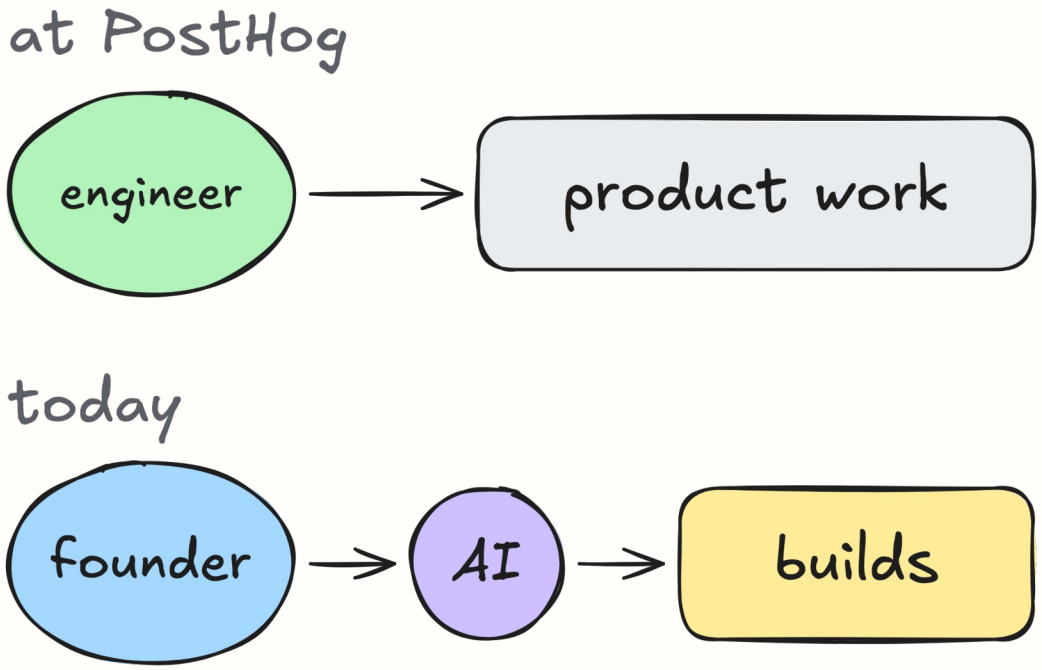
PostHog, "How come we ship so much?" by co-founder James Hawkins



PostHog

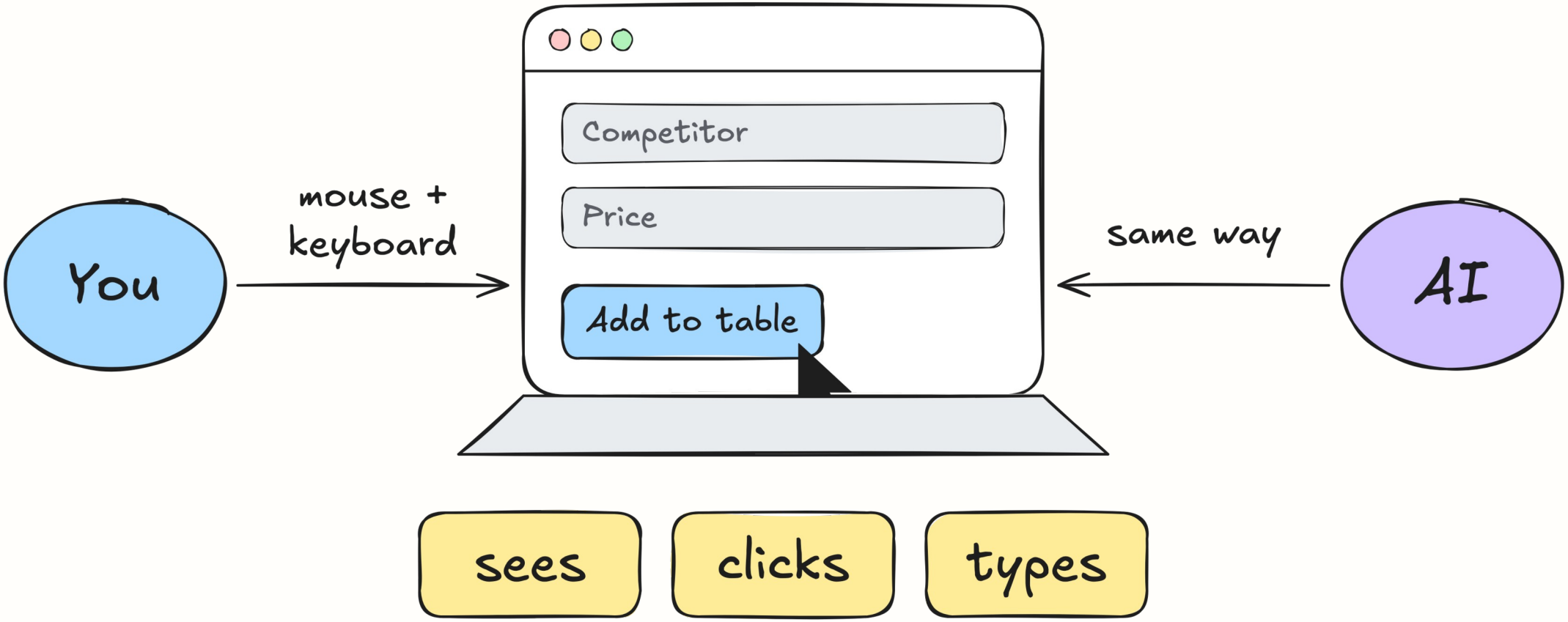
There, engineers do
the product work too.

Today, founders and product people can build too.



Small teams · every number open to everyone · trust over process

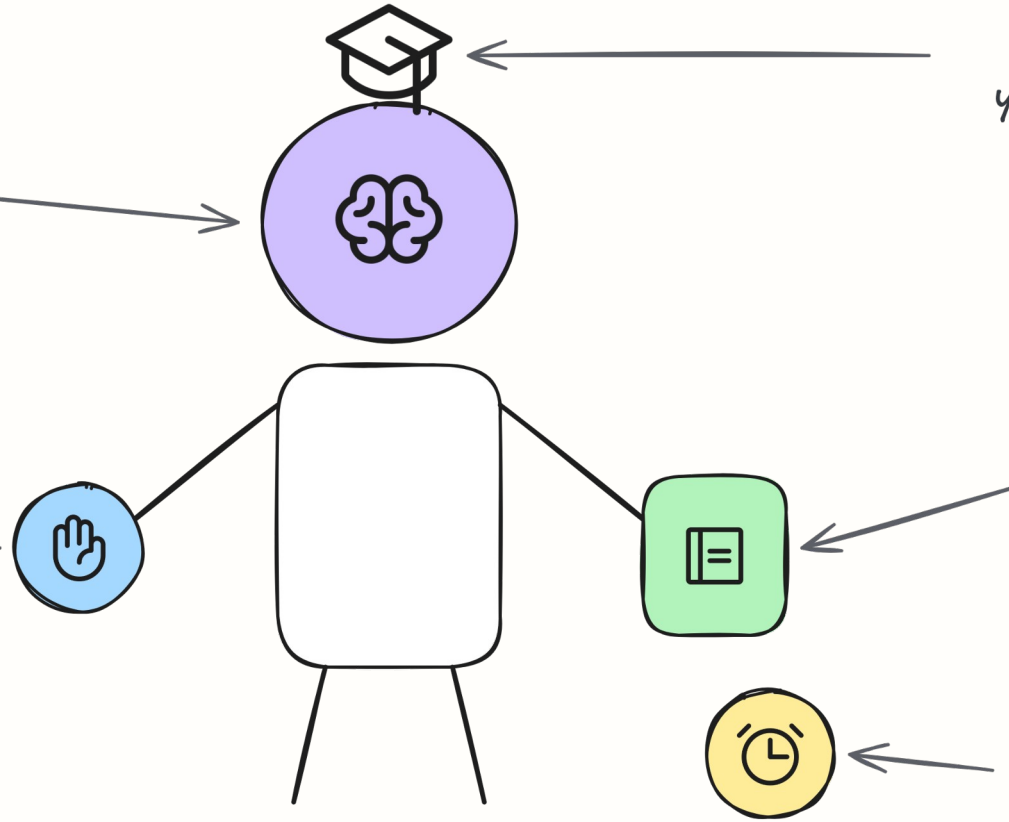
Whatever you do on a computer,
an AI can do it now too.



What turns a chatbot into a colleague

Brain
the model: gets what you ask and thinks it through

Hands
tools: files, email, calendar, spreadsheets



Training
your processes and rules, like a new hire's

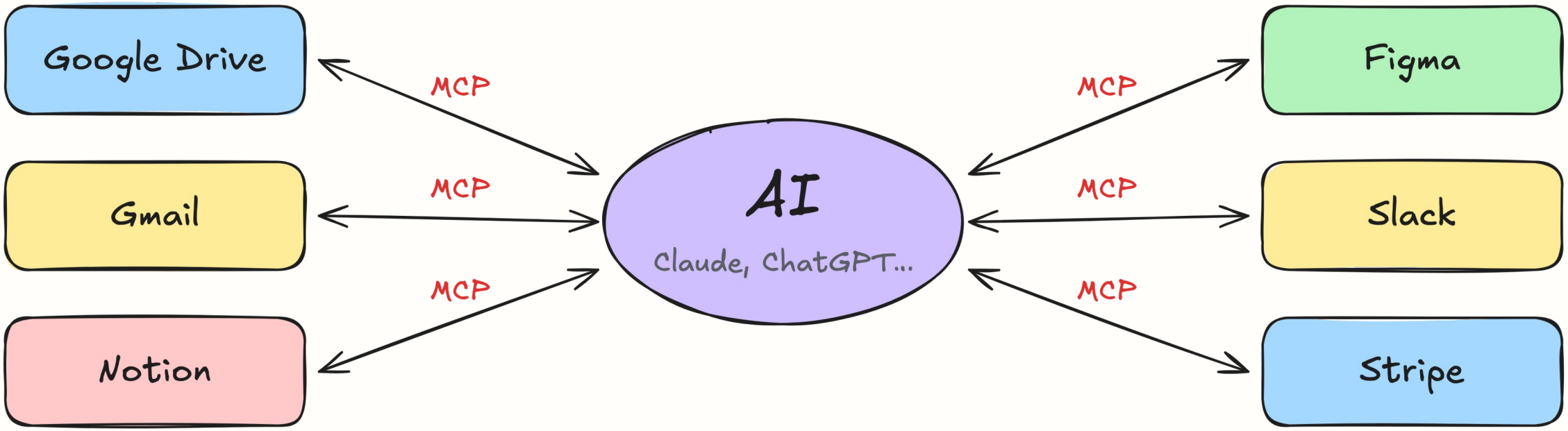
Memory
remembers you and earlier decisions

Schedule
runs by itself: every morning, overnight

Model Context Protocol

MCP: the AI's plug

Like USB-C: one standard, and the AI reaches your tools.



I don't sign up for a service
I can't use through MCP.

Where are you?



Brief it like a smart new hire

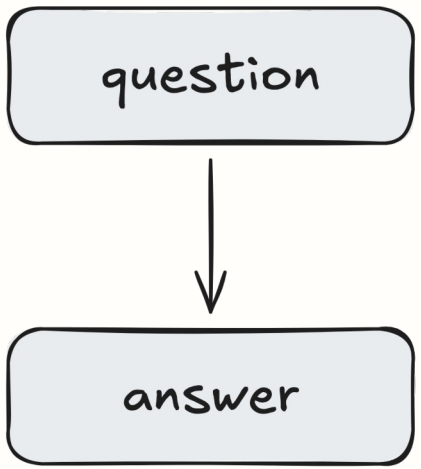
Role	You are a senior product researcher.
Context	Our idea: [the problem the room picked]. Who has it: [your customers].
Task	Find what real users say about it in reviews and forums. Group the complaints into themes, with quotes.
Format	One table of themes, then a short list of what to build first.
Check	Use only what you found. Every quote needs its link. Nothing found? Write "no data".

~~"make it better"~~ → a brief you would give a smart new hire

What makes an agent an agent?

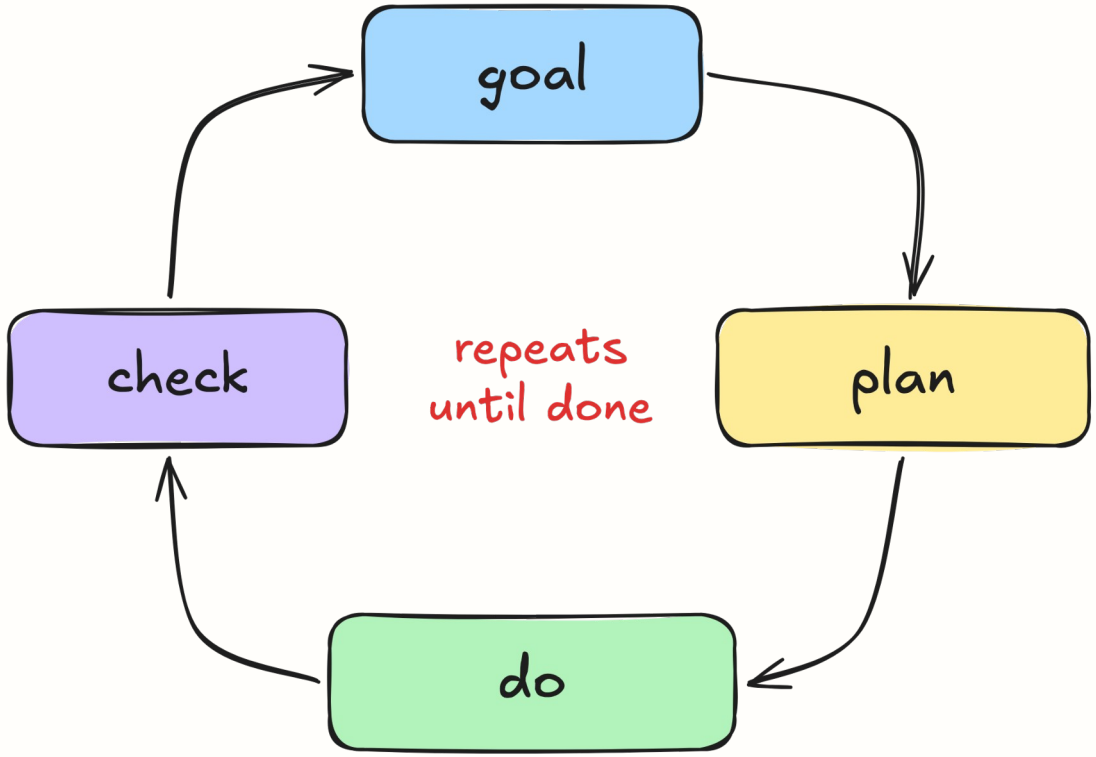
A chat answers. An agent gets a goal and sees it through.

chat



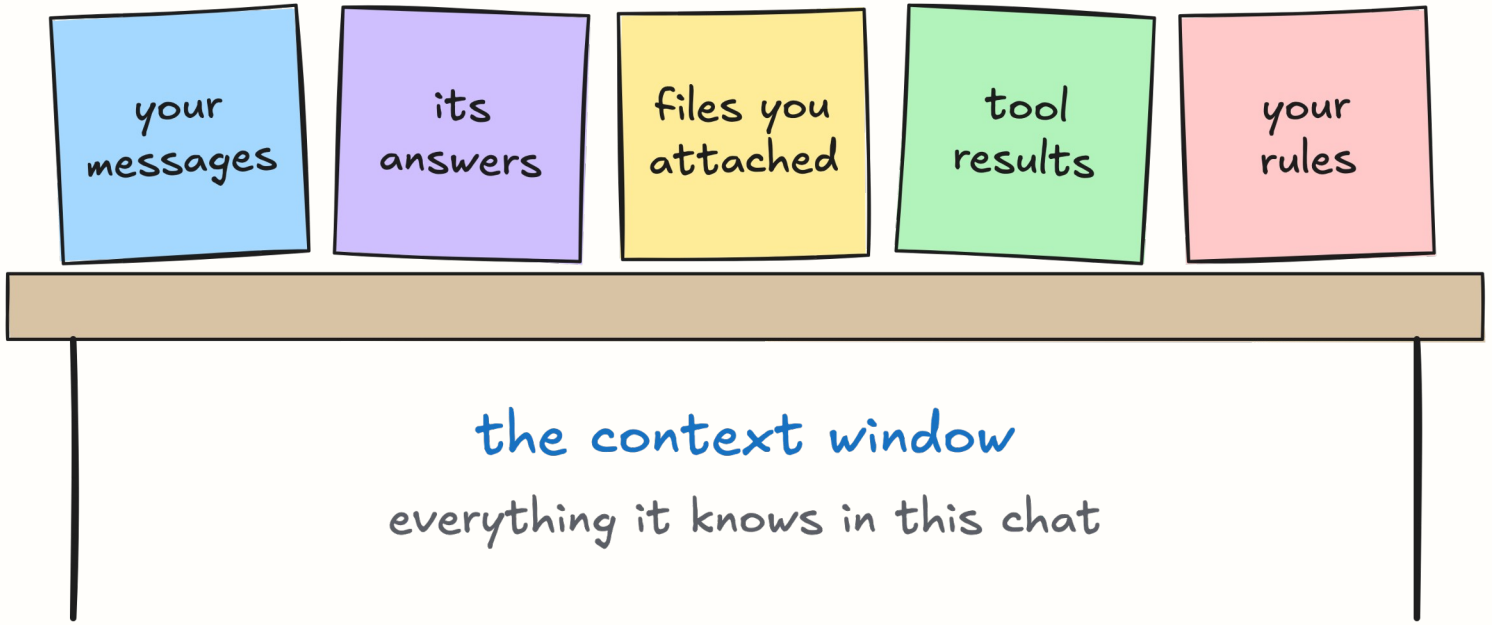
and done

agent



Context, the part nobody explains

Everything it knows sits on one desk



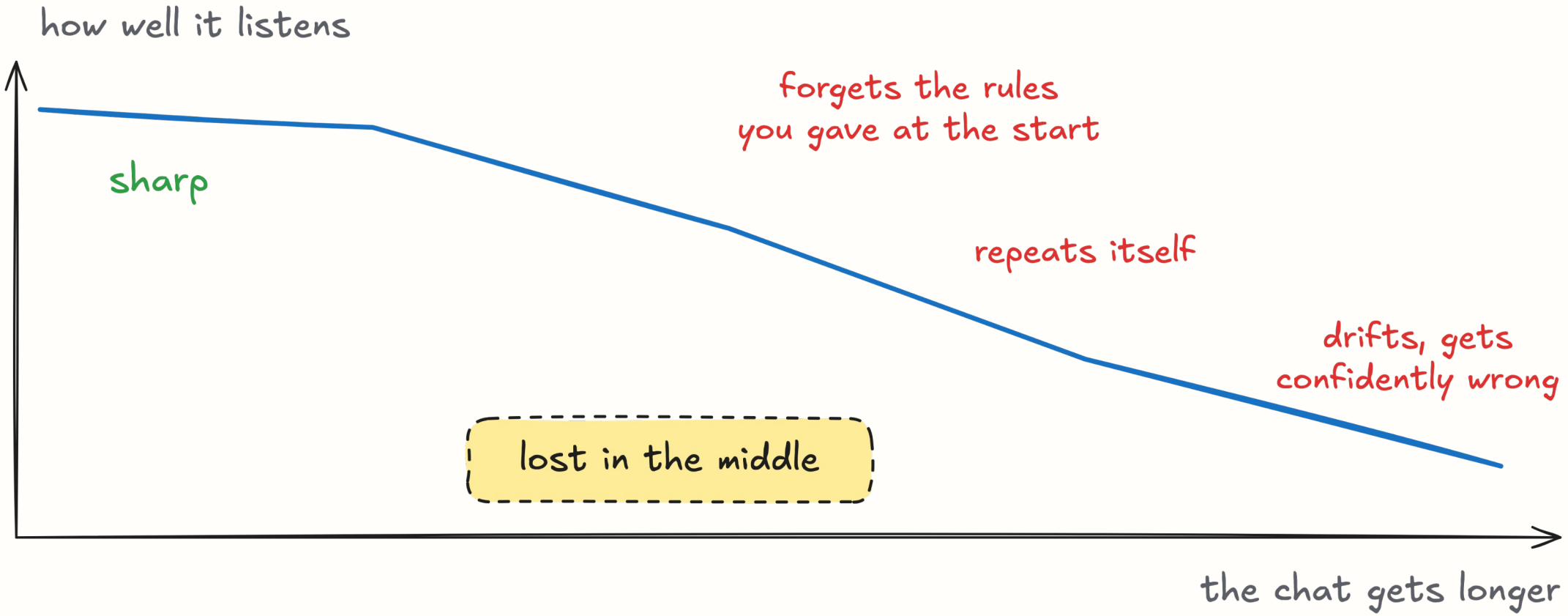
not on the desk

- last week's chat
- your other files
- what you only thought

= it doesn't know it

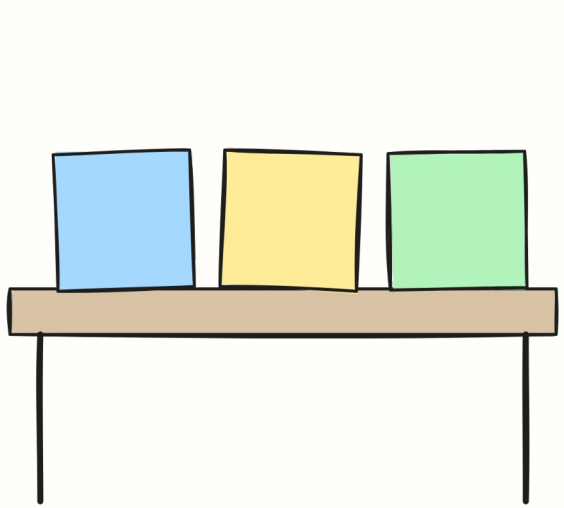
Context rot

The fuller the desk, the worse it listens.



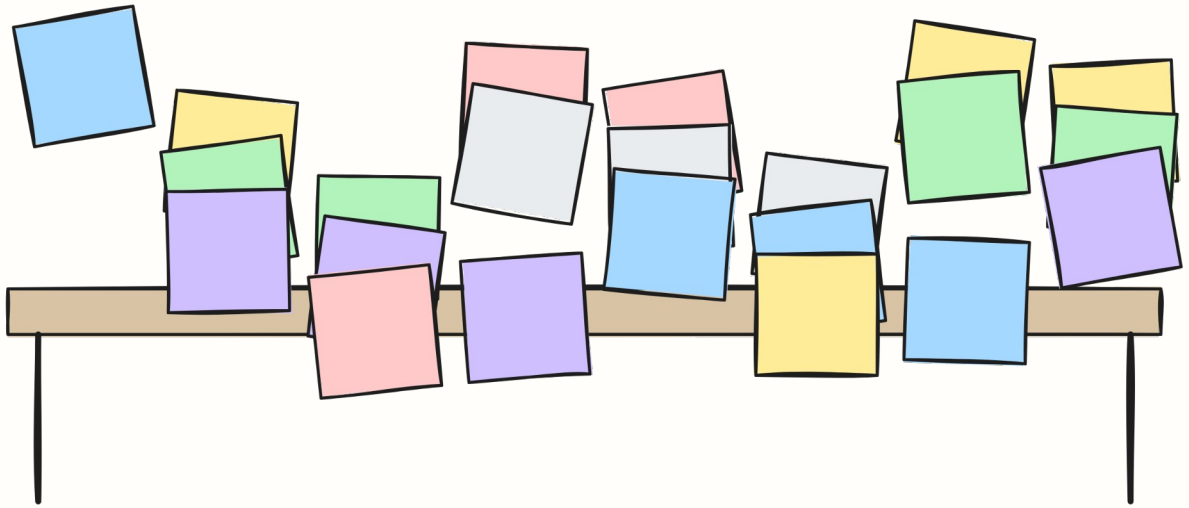
A bigger desk is not a better memory

Huge context windows are real. Huge attention isn't.



small, clean desk

one task, sharp



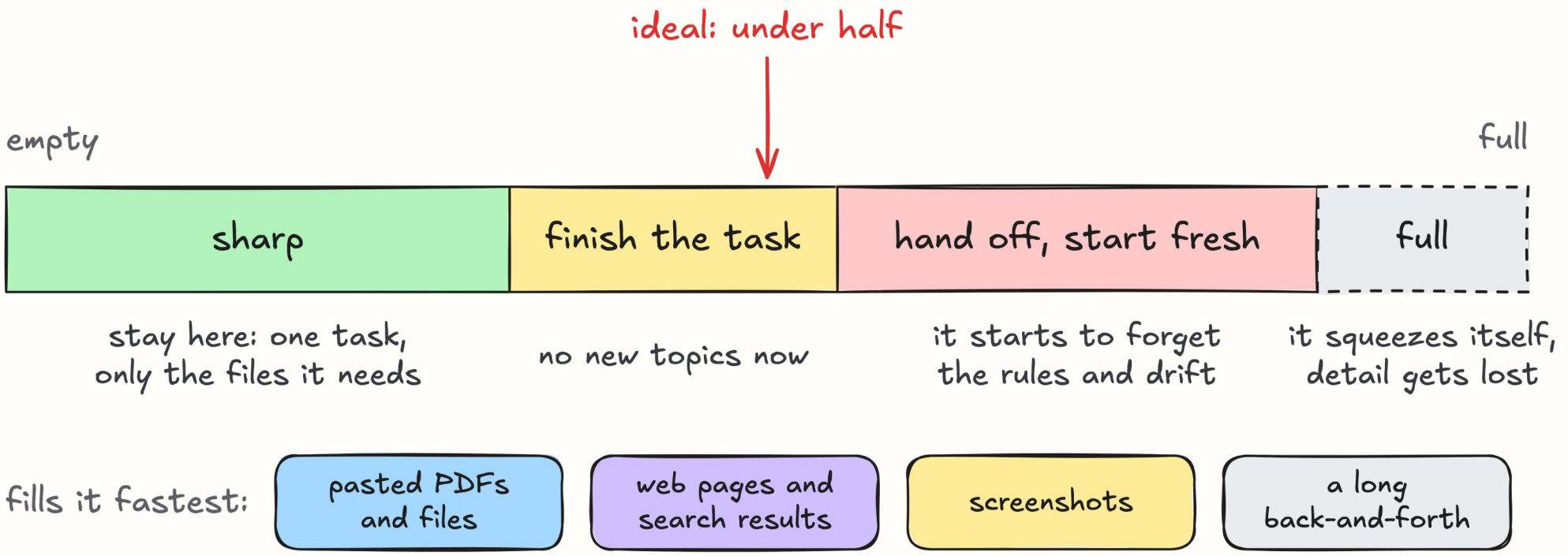
huge, messy desk

it can hold it all, it can't focus on it all

a big desk is for one big read (a whole contract, a codebase), not for one endless chat

How full should the desk be?

Every word, file and tool result takes space on it. Stay in the green.



every message re-reads the whole desk: fuller is slower, pricier and less sharp

Keep the desk clean

Five habits that make every tool smarter, for free.

One task, one chat

new topic?
new chat

Hand off, start fresh

ask for a short summary, paste it into a new chat

Rules in a file

not repeated in every message

Send a helper

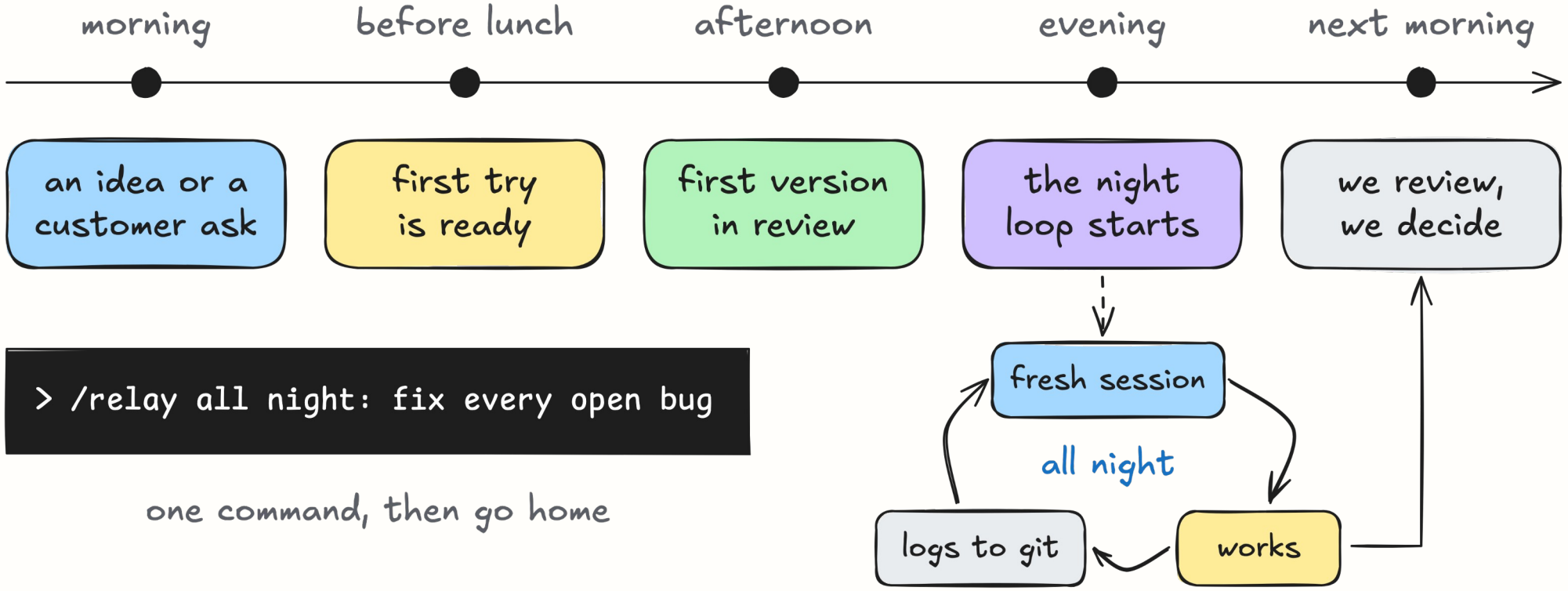
a helper agent reads the pile, brings back the answer

Memory you can read

notes and files you control and can edit

One feature, one day and one night

All the code I pushed last year, I now push every week or two.

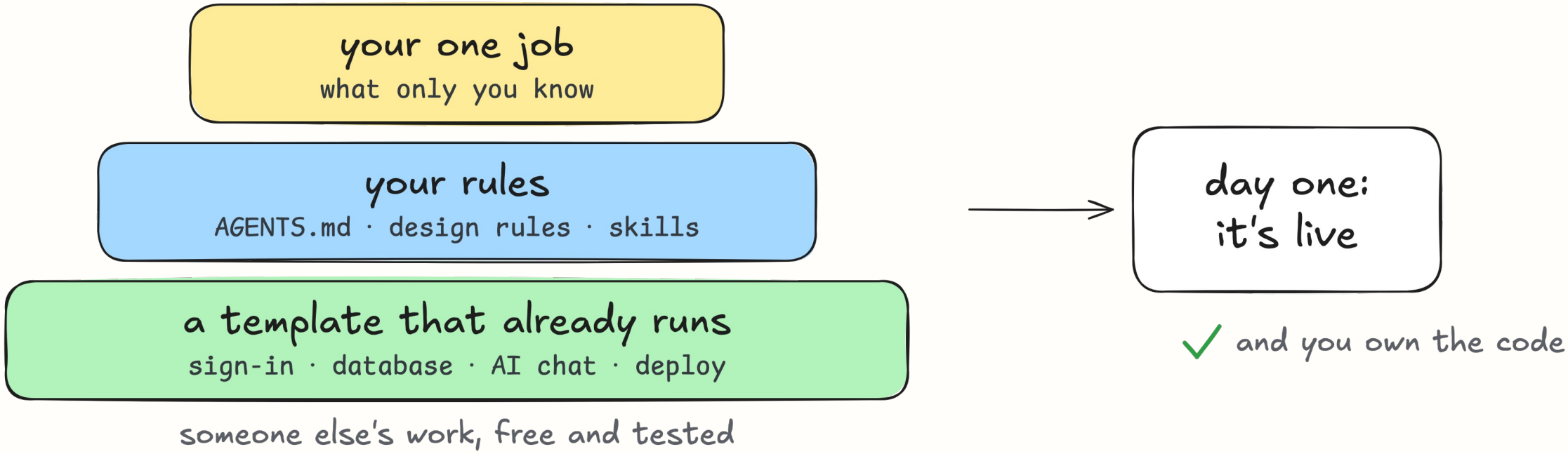



```
> /relay all night: fix every open bug
```

one command, then go home

the decision is ours

Never start from a blank page



the agent copies what it sees: give it good code to copy

Teach it once, not every day

rules file

AGENTS.md / CLAUDE.md

read first, every session:
how we work, what we
never do, where things are

skills

/verify /grill /relay

a workflow I explained
twice, saved once,
called by name

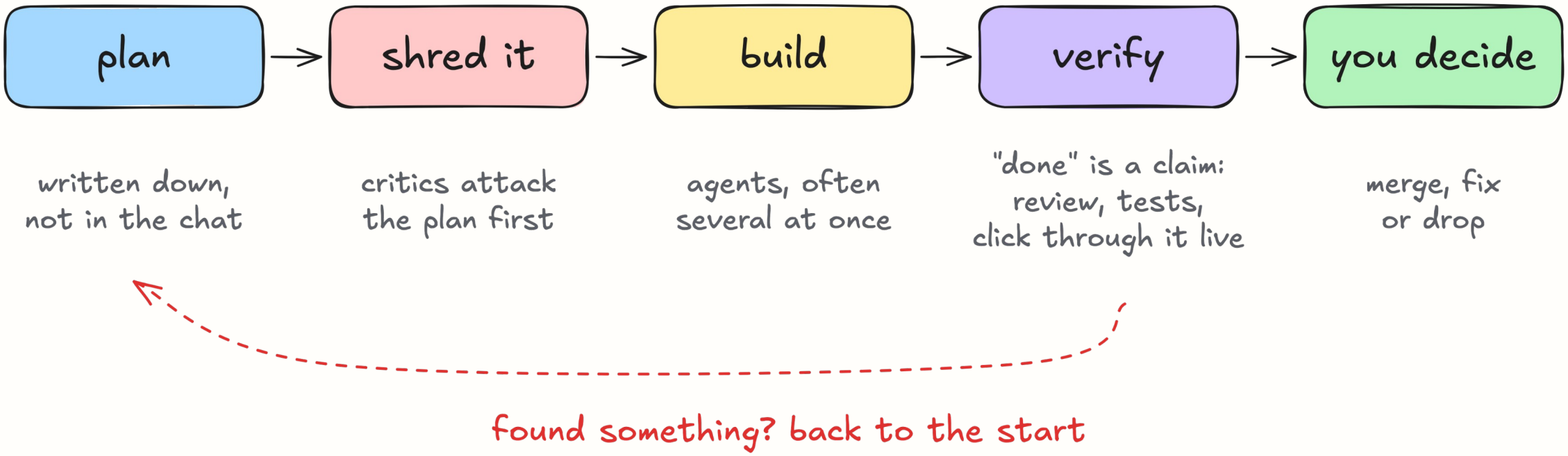
memory

one note per fact

decisions, lessons,
mistakes it must
not repeat

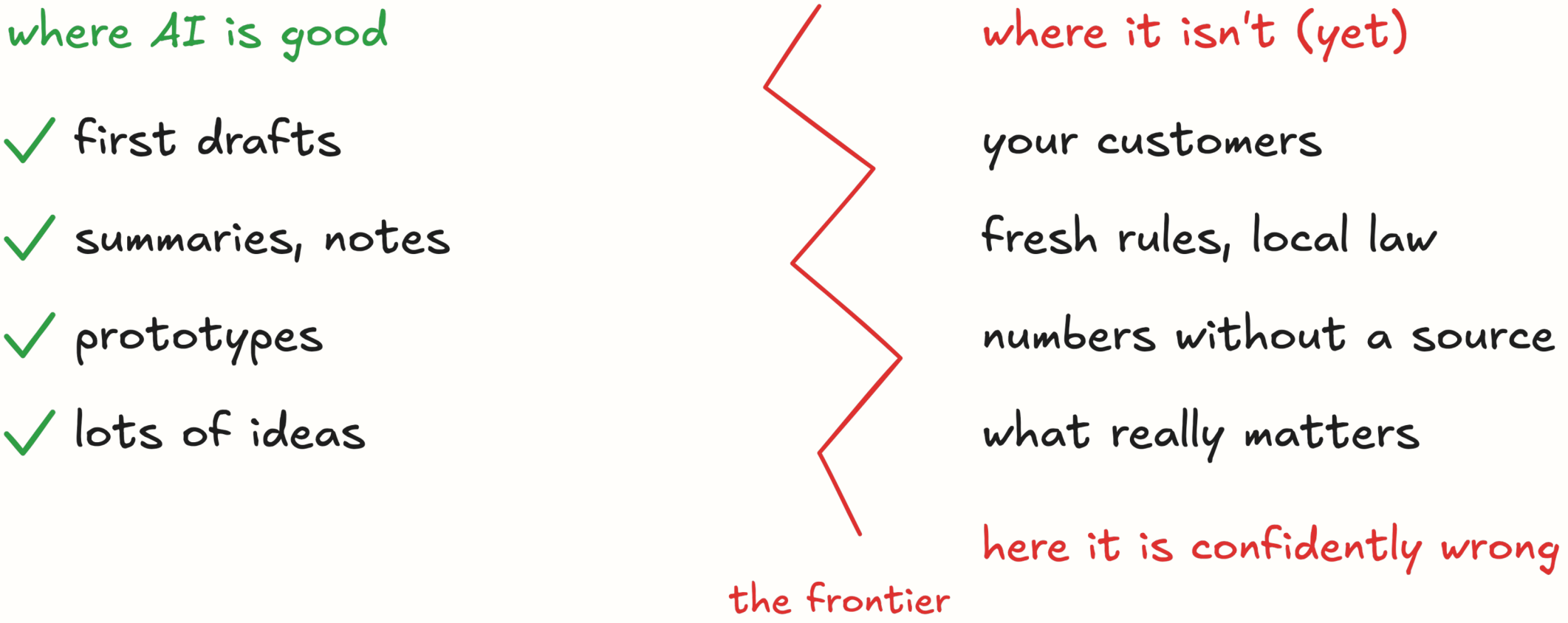
corrected the same thing twice? write it down

Never trust "done"



Know where it stops

Faster and better inside the line. Confidently wrong outside it.



What we cut, and what we never cut

we cut

~~the waiting~~

~~the perfect first draft~~

~~the spec nobody reads~~

we never cut

- ✓ protecting customer data
- ✓ checking the work
- ✓ the decision: that's yours

A prototype takes an afternoon now. For everyone.

Raising money changed

Fewer, bigger bets

more money than ever, into fewer companies

Small teams go further

raise less, later, or only once

The bar moved

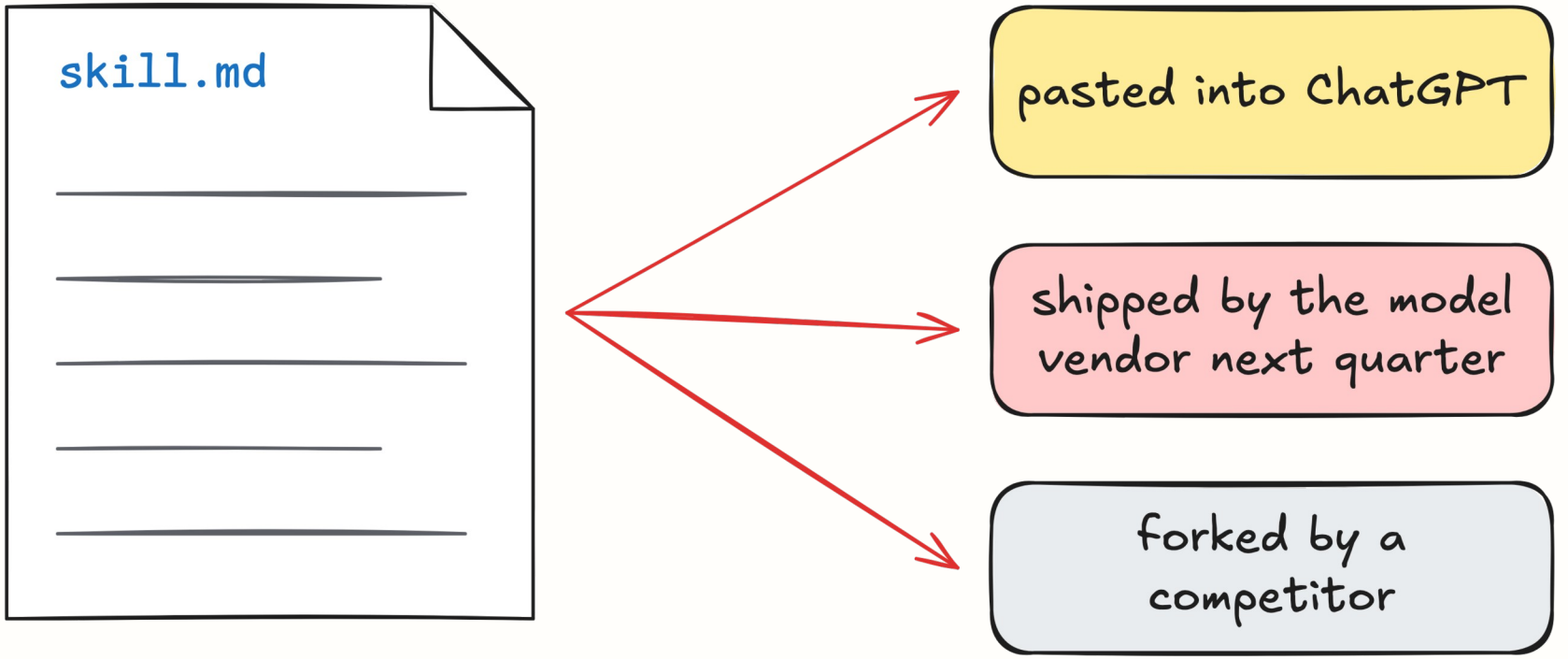
fast growth is expected; durability impresses

A machine reads you first

AI screens your deck and data room

Your product is not a markdown file

If a prompt gets most of your output, you have a demo, not a company.



your whole product?

copied in

an afternoon

The question every investor asks now

"Why can't OpenAI ship this next quarter?"

Answer with what you own that a model doesn't.

counts	doesn't count
✓ data your product creates by doing the work	~~a better prompt~~
✓ the workflow, where the truth lives	~~a nicer chat window~~
✓ customers who already trust you	~~being first~~
✓ local, regulated depth: law, tax, registries	
✓ selling the outcome, not the tool	

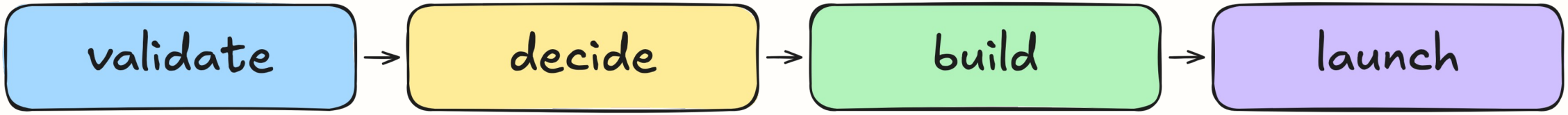
Break

When we're back: we build your idea, live.

Your research is waiting in the chat. Then we build it, live, in one hour.

Let's build it together

From idea to launch, in one sitting

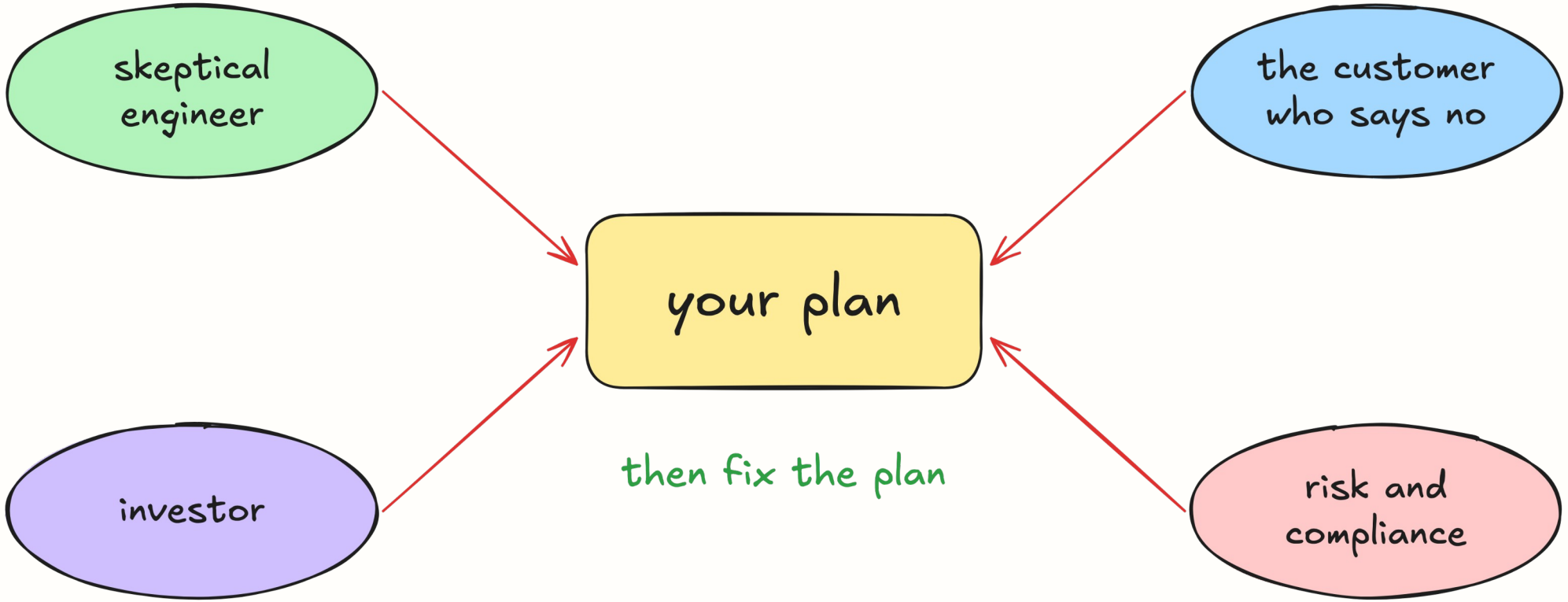


validate	decide	build	launch
real customer words	a simple business case	design from references	launch kit
verify every quote	a one-page spec	clickable prototype	a live link for the room
ideas with evidence	red team it	the real build, live in one hour	automate the ops

your idea, in one afternoon

The most valuable prompt of the day

Red team your own plan



Let the people who would say no speak first, before the market does.

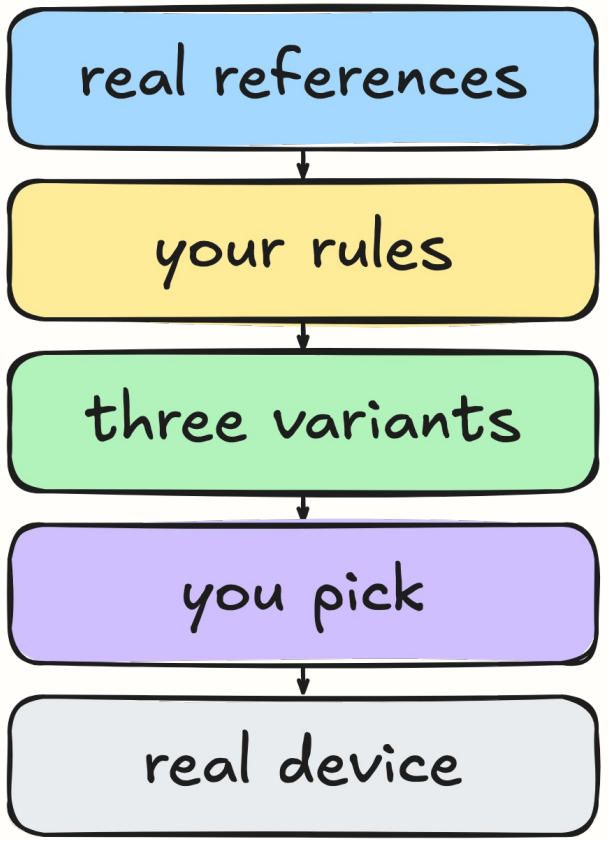
Don't describe it. Show it.

AI makes average design fast. Taste makes it good.

"make it modern and clean"



the same generic *AI look*



screens you admire

colors, type, spacing

side by side

it refines

check it on a phone

How not to ship AI slop

Everything you don't decide, the AI decides the way it does for everyone.

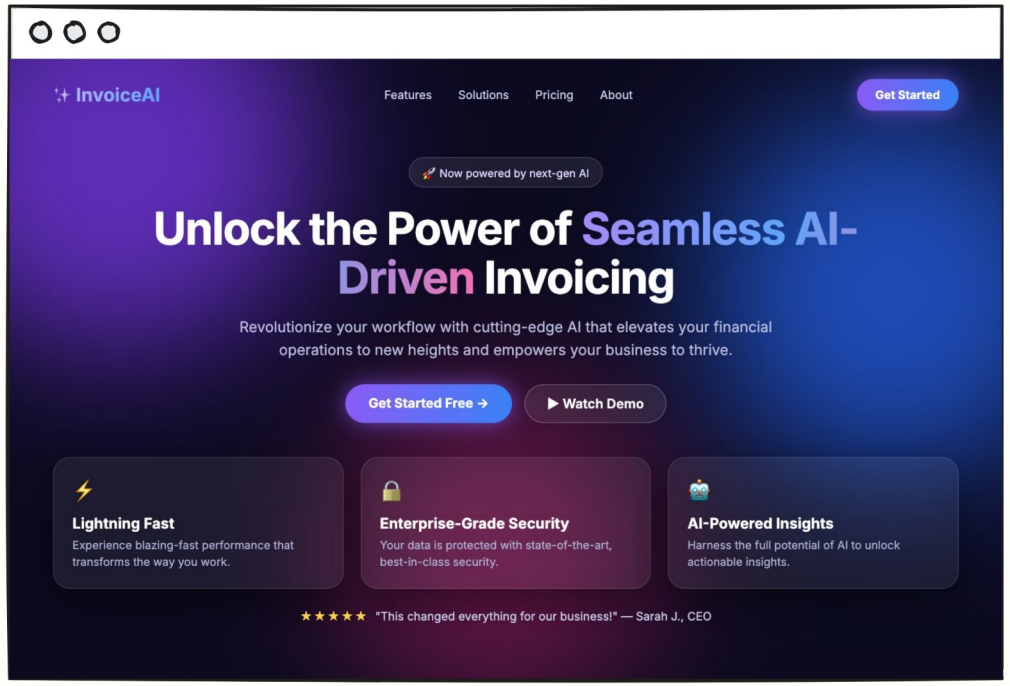
what the AI picks if you don't		what you decide instead
~~purple gradients, glowing blobs~~	→	✓ one brand color, flat surfaces
~~sparkles and emoji on every heading~~	→	✓ one icon set, used sparingly
~~every card the same: rounded, shadowed~~	→	✓ one thing big, the rest quiet
~~"unlock the power of seamless AI"~~	→	✓ plain words: what it does, for whom
~~centered hero and three feature boxes~~	→	✓ a layout taken from a real reference
~~fake reviews, made-up numbers~~	→	✓ real content, honest empty states
~~only ever seen in the chat preview~~	→	✓ clicked through on a real phone

Taste is mostly saying no.

Same AI. Different brief.

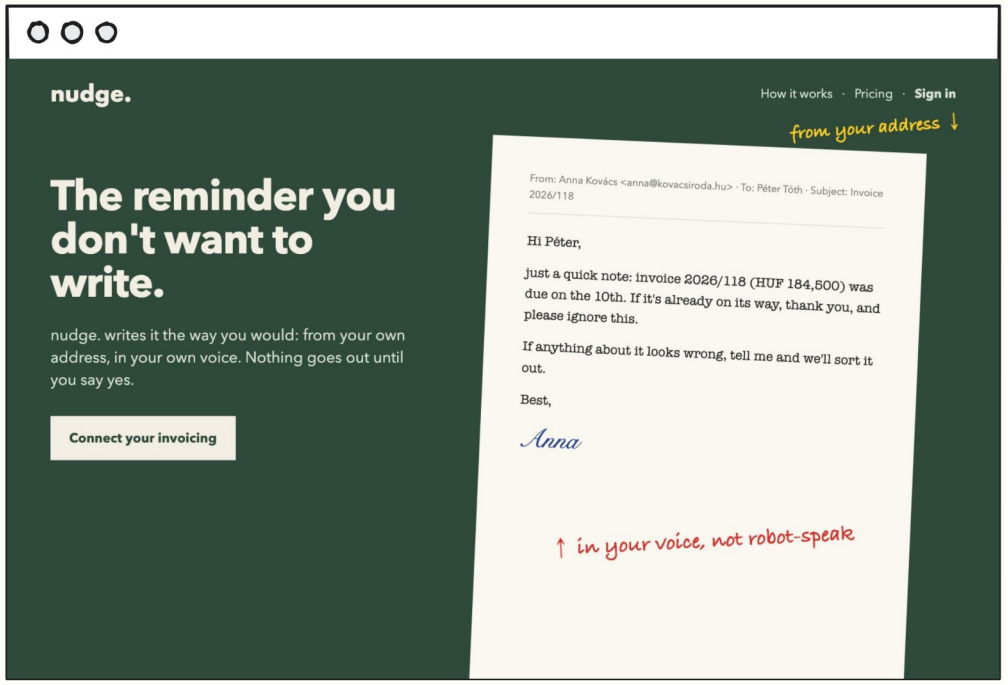
Both pages were made by AI in minutes. Only one was told what not to do.

"make a modern landing page"



gradient text, glow, sparkles,
filler words, three boxes, fake praise

a reference, rules and one idea



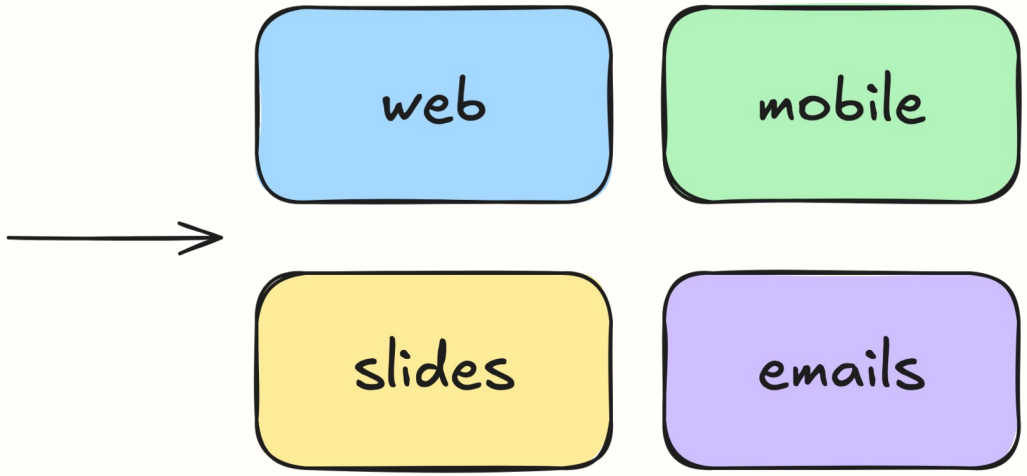
says what it does, in your voice,
one idea instead of three boxes

Write your taste down once

A short rules file the AI reads every time, on every surface.

design-rules.md

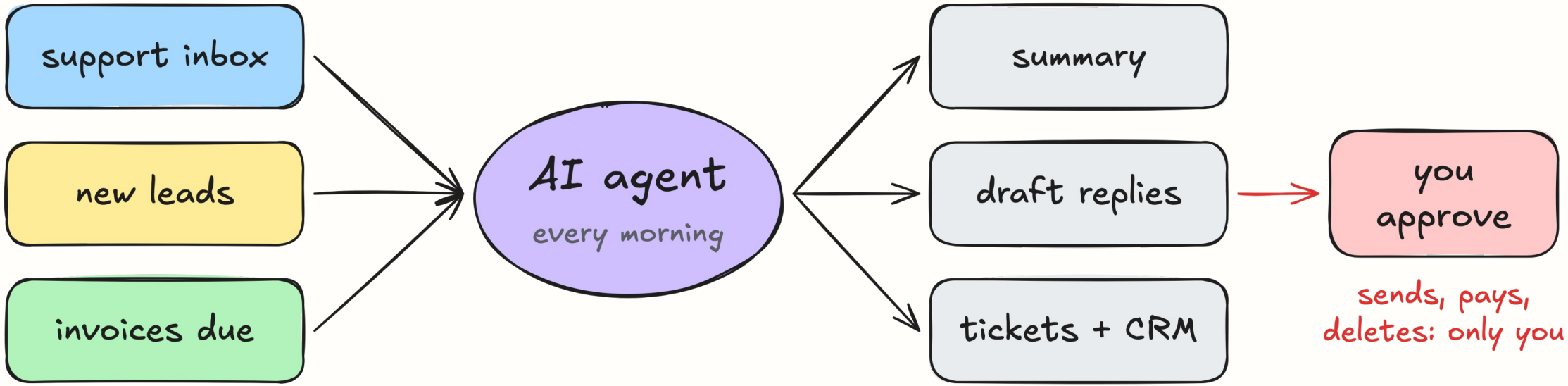
- ✓ one ink color for actions
- ✓ one font family for the app
- ✓ small radius on controls, larger on cards
- ✓ thin lines, no gradients, no heavy shadows
- ✓ every screen has an empty state



same taste, everywhere

Then let it run the boring part

Automate the operations



It drafts, you approve. Anything that sends, pays or deletes waits for you.

Start with the task you hate most

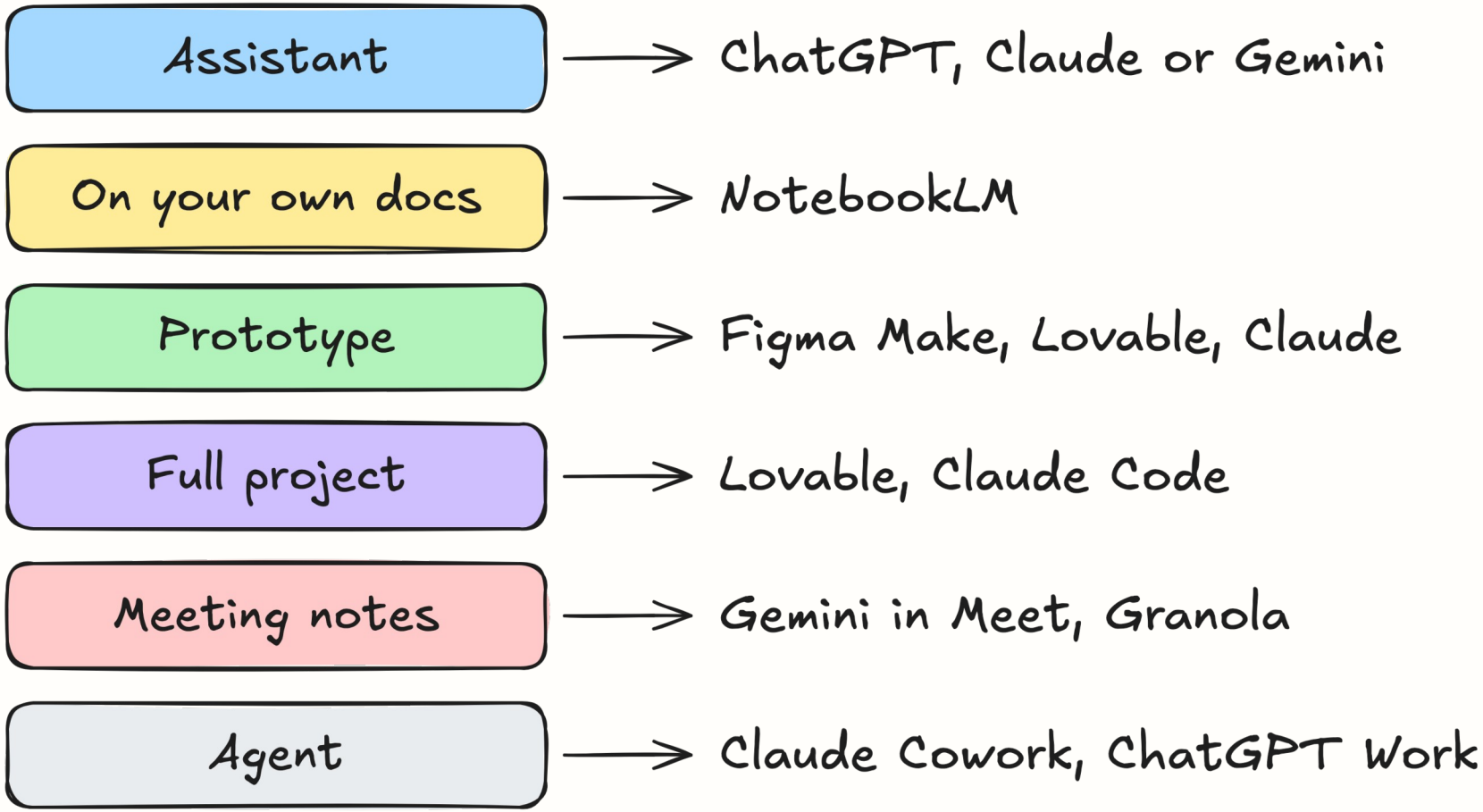
Your AI transformation starts there, not with a strategy deck.



why this one

- ✓ you know it inside out
- ✓ so you can judge the output
- ✓ it comes back every week
- ✓ you feel the win on day one

Where to start



Your first week with AI

- [ ] **Mon** pick the task you hate most
- [ ] **Tue** make a project with your context and rules
- [ ] **Wed** connect one tool through MCP
- [ ] **Thu** write down what you never cut
- [ ] **Fri** let it run, then keep it or drop it

If you ask: the small things

Small tricks that add up

several agents at once, each in its own copy of the project

it asks me with buttons to click, not paragraphs

it pings my phone when it's stuck or done

real screens I admire before any design

every change checked live, not just "tests pass"

every task leaves a written record

If you ask: what to paste on Monday

Five prompts to steal

Research

real customer words, every quote with its link

Red team

the people who would say no speak first

Handoff

decisions, open questions, next step, then a fresh chat

After the call

their words back, what we agreed, the next step

Meeting notes

decisions and owners, not a transcript

each one: role, context, task, format, check

All of them in the repo, ready to paste.

If you ask: where every project starts

Files I never start without

AGENTS.md

how we work, read
first every session

design-rules.md

my taste,
written down once

never-list.md

what the agent
never touches

ask-with-options.md

every question comes
as buttons to click

review-prompt.md

a fresh session
reviews the work

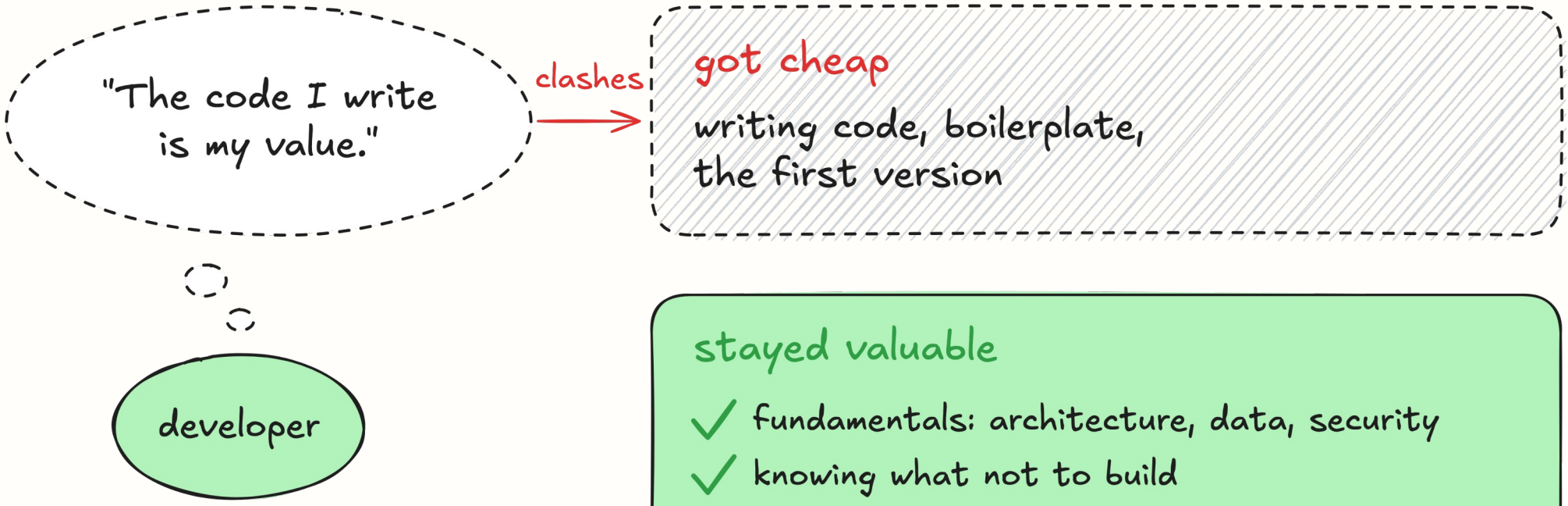
interview-notes.md

customer words,
not opinions

Copy them from the repo, then make them yours.

Code got cheap. Judgment didn't.

Many developers still believe writing code is their value.



Cut the waiting.

Keep the craft.

Questions?

Zoltán Fodor · zoltanfodor.dev

Slides, prompts, skills and resources:
github.com/ritmillio/building-in-the-age-of-ai